

Tether: A Holistic Pain Management App

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Transition into UX for Healthcare: Week 1 Assignment

September 2026



Healthcare Problem: Fragmented care when managing chronic pain

- Chronic pain is a complex health condition in which pain severity and duration can be impacted by a combination of biological, psychological, and social factors
- Evidence-based holistic pain treatments (e.g., psychological therapies, physical or manual therapies), close management of medications, and self-management (e.g., ice/heat, rest, exercise) is the gold standard for managing pain long-term
- **Optimal pain management requires close communication and coordination across care providers, care teams, and the patient to ensure that care isn't fragmented and patients don't experience setbacks**

Potential Solutions

Using a Reddit search thread for "holistic pain management," the Figma Make AI chatbot provided the following app ideas to help me solve my problem:

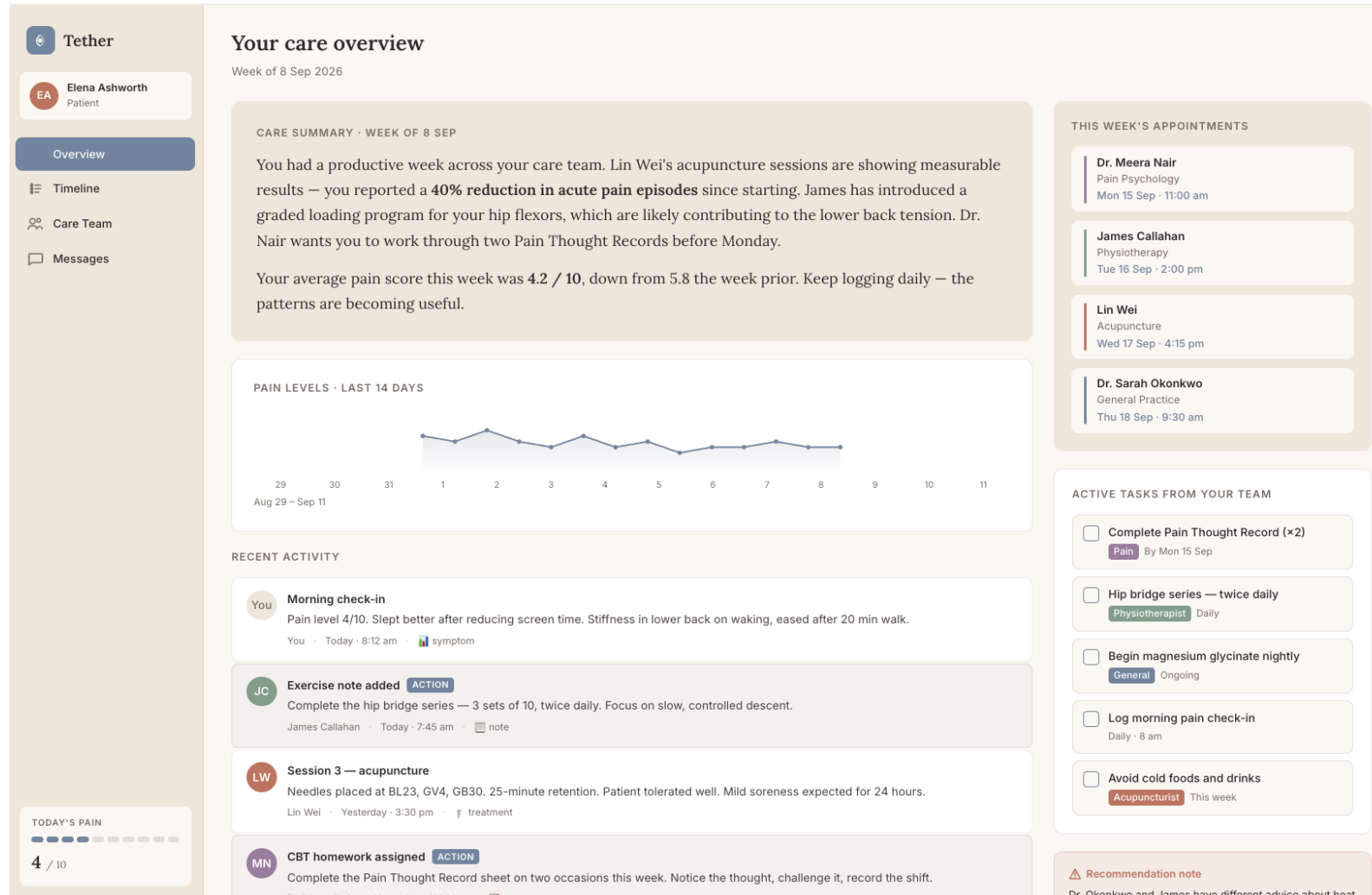
1. **Pain Pattern Intelligence – "Ripple"** A smart symptom tracker that correlates pain flares with overlooked lifestyle variables – barometric pressure, menstrual cycle, dietary logs, sleep debt, and stress levels. Unlike existing trackers that just log numbers, Ripple surfaces non-obvious triggers using AI and presents them as visual "ripple" timelines. The core differentiator: exportable doctor reports pre-formatted for clinic visits, so patients stop having to reconstruct their history from memory.
2. **Nervous System Retraining – "Rewire"** Targets the growing evidence around neuroplastic/central sensitization pain (the Curable angle, but more structured). A progressive, curriculum-style app with daily 10-minute sessions combining somatic tracking, expressive writing, and graded exposure exercises. Progress is gamified as a literal "rewiring" visualization – users watch their nervous system diagram calm over weeks. Built-in community cohorts so users move through the program with a small accountability group.
3. **Movement as Medicine – "Flux"** Fills the gap between "rest and do nothing" and "push through it." Flux offers adaptive, day-by-day movement programs (yoga, aquatic therapy, tai chi, stretching) that adjust in real time based on your daily pain check-in. On high-pain days it scales down to breathwork and gentle range-of-motion; on good days it progressively loads more. Targets the common Reddit complaint that most apps don't account for how wildly pain fluctuates day to day.
4. **Integrative Care Coordinator – "Tether"** A care-team hub that bridges the gap between a patient's GP, physical therapist, acupuncturist, psychologist, and any other providers. Patients log symptoms and treatments; all providers see a shared timeline. Tether surfaces what's working across modalities using outcome tracking, and flags conflicting recommendations between providers. Addresses the most common Reddit frustration: holistic care is fragmented and no one practitioner sees the whole picture.

Prototype Development: Tether

I chose the following option as it seemed to best address my healthcare problem and confirmed that health care fragmentation is a big problem for patients with chronic pain:

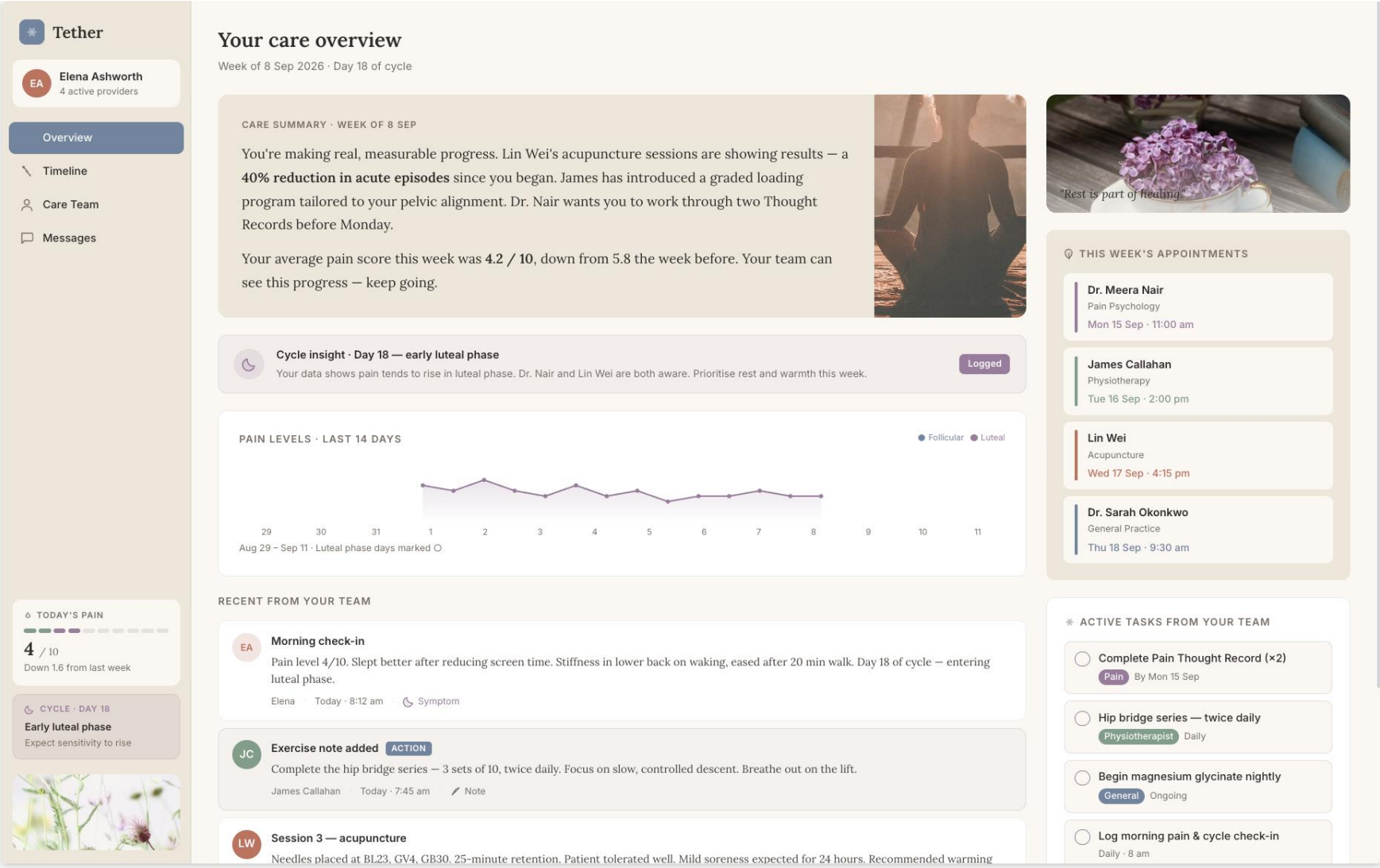
Integrative Care Coordinator – "Tether" A care-team hub that bridges the gap between a patient's GP, physical therapist, acupuncturist, psychologist, and any other providers. Patients log symptoms and treatments; all providers see a shared timeline. Tether surfaces what's working across modalities using outcome tracking, and flags conflicting recommendations between providers. Addresses the most common Reddit frustration: holistic care is fragmented and no one practitioner sees the whole picture.

Tether Prototype Development: Version 1

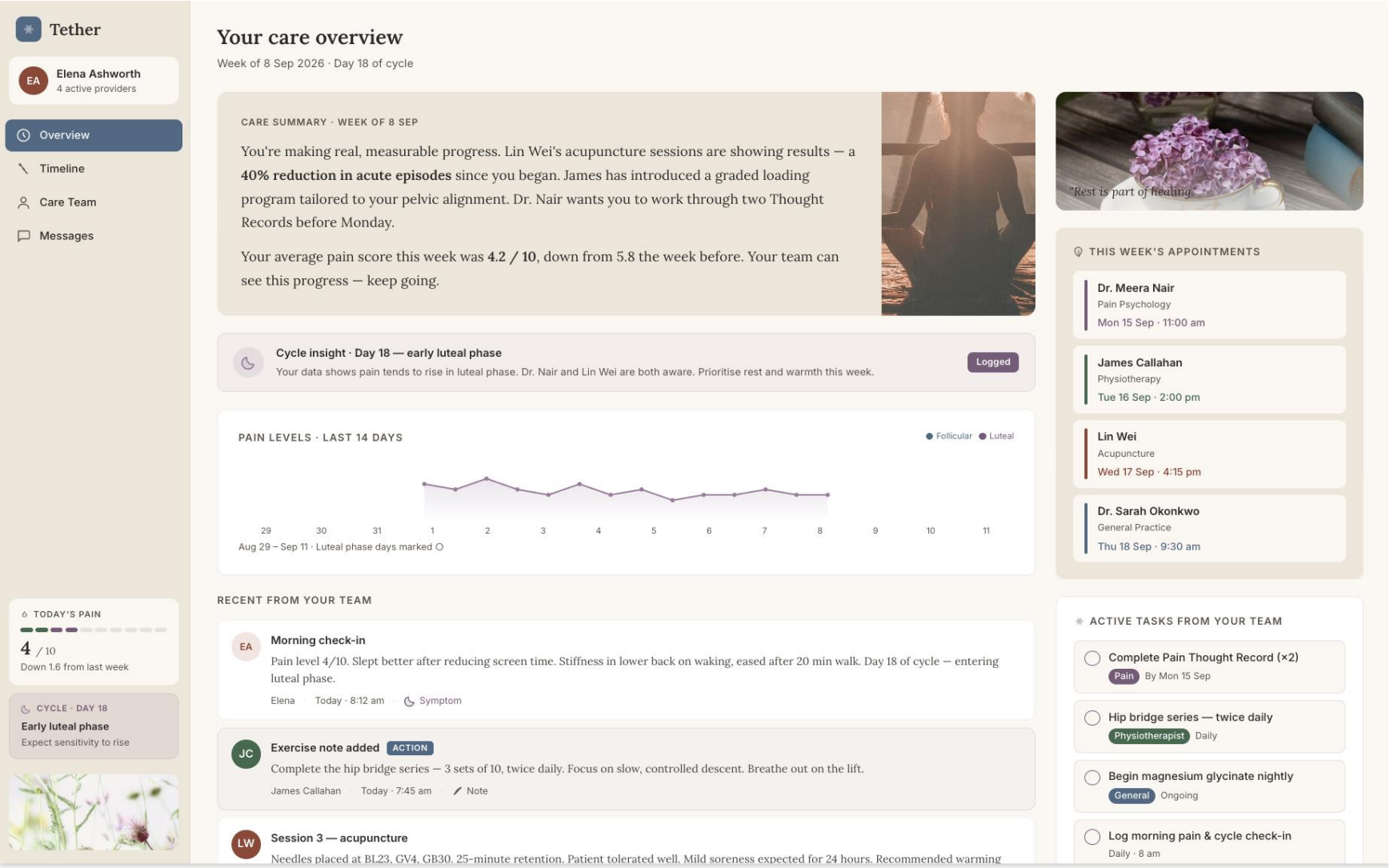


- Overview – the signature two-column layout: a warm narrative care summary (Lora serif) beside a crisp action stack.
- Includes an interactive pain trend chart, this week's appointments with provider color coding, checkable tasks from each provider, and a flagged recommendation conflict alert.
- Timeline – a filterable chronological log of all entries from the patient and every provider (notes, treatments, symptoms, medications), with flagged action items surfaced visually.
- Care Team – provider cards that expand a detail panel on click, showing their latest note, assigned tasks, next appointment, and a message button.
- The palette, typography (Lora + Inter), 10px radii, and warm tinted surfaces follow the Humanist Care direction throughout.

Tether Prototype Development: Version 2



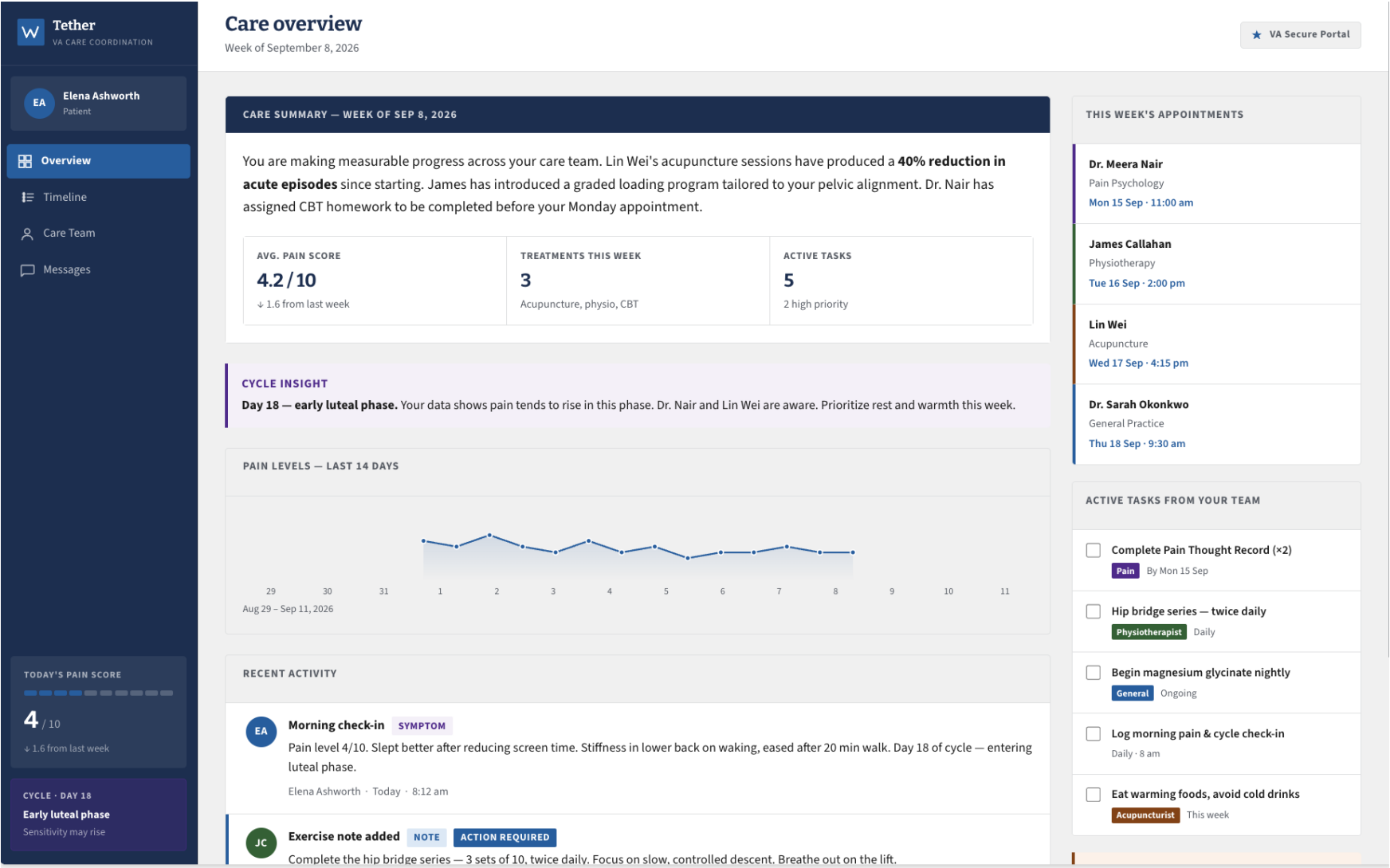
Tether Prototype Development: Version 3



I also wanted to make sure that the app met accessibility standards to ensure that women with disabilities can successfully use it.

Figma changed the contrast of colors to ensure that the prototype meets accessibility standards.

Tether Prototype Development: Version 4



Tether Prototype Development V4: Shared Care Timeline

W

Tether

VA CARE COORDINATION

EA

Elena Ashworth

Patient

Overview

Timeline

Care Team

Messages

TODAY'S PAIN SCORE

4

/ 10

↓ 1.6 from last week

CYCLE · DAY 18

Early luteal phase

Sensitivity may rise

Shared care timeline

All entries from you and your providers

VA Secure Portal

All entries

Symptoms

Treatments

Notes

Medications

TODAY

EA

Morning check-in

SYMPTOM

Pain level 4/10. Slept better after reducing screen time. Stiffness in lower back on waking, eased after 20 min walk. Day 18 of cycle — entering luteal phase.

Elena Ashworth · Today · 8:12 am

JC

Exercise note added

NOTE

ACTION REQUIRED

Complete the hip bridge series — 3 sets of 10, twice daily. Focus on slow, controlled descent. Breathe out on the lift.

James Callahan · Today · 7:45 am

YESTERDAY

LW

Session 3 — acupuncture

TREATMENT

Needles placed at BL23, GV4, GB30. 25-minute retention. Patient tolerated well. Mild soreness expected for 24 hours. Recommended warming foods this week.

Lin Wei · Yesterday · 3:30 pm

MN

CBT homework assigned

NOTE

ACTION REQUIRED

Complete the Pain Thought Record sheet on two occasions this week. Notice the thought, challenge it, record the shift.

Dr. Meera Nair · Yesterday · 11:00 am

10 SEP

SO

Medication review

MEDICATION

Naproxen 500mg reduced to as-needed only. Added magnesium glycinate 400mg nightly for muscle tension and sleep. Iron levels to be tested next visit.

Dr. Sarah Okonkwo · 10 Sep · 9:30 am

8 SEP

Session 3 — physiotherapy

TREATMENT

Tether Prototype Development V4: Care Team

W

Tether

VA CARE COORDINATION

EA

Elena Ashworth

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TODAY'S PAIN SCORE

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CYCLE · DAY 18

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Sensitivity may rise

Care team

4 connected providers

★ VA Secure Portal

SO

Dr. Sarah Okonkwo

General Practitioner

"Reviewed pain diary. Considering referral to pain specialist if no improvement in 6 weeks. Noted correlation between pain scores and late-cycle phase — worth tracking."

Next: Thu 18 Sep · 9:30 am

JC

James Callahan

Physiotherapist

"Hip flexor tension contributing to lower back pain. Starting graded loading program. Pelvic floor engagement is a priority before we progress to loading."

Next: Tue 16 Sep · 2:00 pm

MN

Dr. Meera Nair

Pain Psychologist

"CBT session focused on pain catastrophising. Elena is showing strong self-awareness. Introduced somatic body scanning to interrupt flare-anxiety cycles."

Next: Mon 15 Sep · 11:00 am

IW

Lin Wei

Acupuncturist

"Third session. Targeting lumbar and SI joint points. Hormonal phase noted as a factor — will align future sessions with follicular phase where possible."

Next: Wed 17 Sep · 4:15 pm

10

Tether Prototype Development V4: Secure Messages

W

Tether

VA CARE COORDINATION

EA

Elena Ashworth

Patient

Overview

Timeline

Care Team

Messages

TODAY'S PAIN SCORE

4 / 10

↓ 1.6 from last week

CYCLE · DAY 18

Early luteal phase

Sensitivity may rise

Secure messages

Messages with your care team

★ VA Secure Portal

CARE TEAM MESSAGES

SO

Okonkwo

Sep 10

No fasting needed for iron — j...

JC

Callahan

Today

1

How is the hip bridge ser...

MN

Nair

Yesterday

Remember to complete both t...

LW

Wei

Sep 10

Prioritise warming foods and ...

JC

James Callahan

Physiotherapist

JC

Good morning — how did the hip bridge exercises feel yesterday?

9:14 am

JC

Morning James! Did them twice — felt the burn on the third set but no pain.

9:42 am

JC

That's exactly where we want you. If it tips into sharp or shooting pain, stop and message me. Otherwise, keep going — you're building the right foundation.

9:50 am

JC

How is the hip bridge series feeling? Any discomfort?

11:30 am

Write a secure message to your provider...

Send

11

Next Steps

- Consider new features (e.g., menu of additional treatment options, education)
- Consider additional UI issues
- Generate a mobile version of the app